1 Transition to the 18th Century

Advent of Europeans

Before the British established formal rule in India, trade between India and European nations was already prevalent, facilitated through routes via Syria, Egypt, Silk route and the Oxus valley. The 15th century in Europe marked the Age of Exploration, with notable discoverers like Columbus reaching America in 1492 and Vasco da Gama arriving in Calicut, India, in 1498 via a new sea route. This era saw European powers—mainly the Portuguese, Dutch, English, and French—competing to establish trade networks and influence in Asia, laying the groundwork for major cultural, economic, and political changes in India.

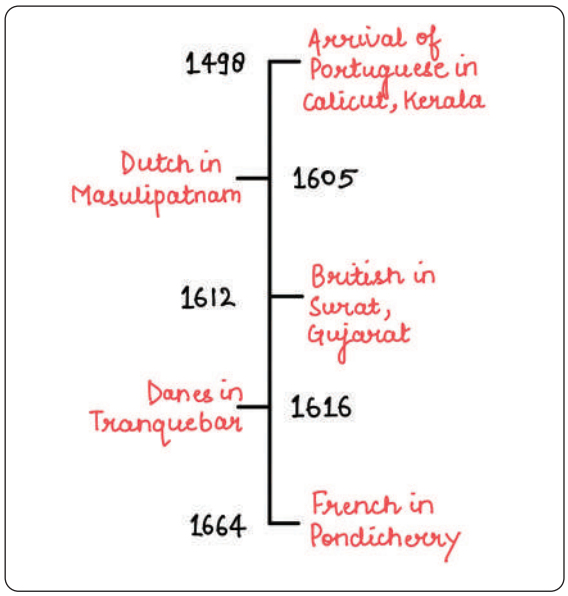

Fig. 1.1: Advent of Europeans
Diagram Type: *Timeline*

Why Europeans Came to India: A Catalyst for Exploration

The arrival of Europeans in India wasn't a random event. Several key factors ignited the Age of Exploration:

- **Blocked Trade Routes:** Ottomans controlling land routes to Asia forced Europeans to find a sea route for cheaper goods and access to lucrative markets, including those in India.
- **The Sea Route Opens:** Explorers like Diaz and da Gama found the sea route to India, bypassing Arab dominance.
- **Royal Backing:** Strong monarchs saw exploration as a path to wealth and glory, sponsoring expeditions.
- **Tech Boosts Exploration:** Advancements in navigation tools like the compass and astrolabe made long voyages possible.
- **Profit & Religion:** Dreams of Asian riches and spreading Christianity motivated explorers and investors.
- **Joint Stock Companies Emerge:** This new business model shared risk and funded large-scale trade ventures.

These factors launched Europe's Age of Exploration, culminating in their arrival in India and a forever changed world of trade.

Portuguese Rule in India

Pioneering Arrivals (1498-1509):

- **Vasco da Gama (1498): First Footsteps, Trade Domination** - Established trading post like cannanore, cochin and calicut, aimed for monopoly control.
- **Francisco De Almeida (1505-1509):** First Viceroy of Portuguese India - He destroyed muslim trade by seizing Aden, Ormuz and mallaca, and Implemented the **Blue Water Policy** to ensure naval dominance.

Afonso de Albuquerque (1509-1515):

- **Architect of Portuguese Supremacy: Strategic Control, Key Territories & Local Integration** - Gained strategic control of the Indian Ocean, seized Goa from the sultan of Bijapur in 1510 and Bhatkal, implemented policies like residing and marrying locally.
- **"Policy of Imperialism": Trade introduce new crops such as tobacco and Cashew Nut** on controlling trade routes and securing spice sources.
- **Expansion Across India:** Established Portuguese settlements in various locations.

Consolidation Under Nino de Cunha (1529-1538):

- **Nino de Cunha (1529-1538): Shifting Capital & Eastward Expansion** - Moved the capital to Goa, expanded Portuguese territory beyond the western coast, extended authority to the eastern shores.

Causes of Decline of Portuguese

1. Emergence of powerful dynasty in Egypts, Persia
2. Rise of Maratha as maratha captured Salsette and bassein in 1739 from Portuguese

3. Religious conversion policy made Hindus resentful
4. Discovery of Brazil diverted colonialising activities of portugal to west
5. Rise of european Competitor such as English and Dutch

Contribution of Portuguese in India

- **Medicine:** Portuguese scholars, such as **Garcia da Orta**, enriched India's medical knowledge with the first treatise on medicinal herbs in **1563**.
- **Cash Crop Cultivation:** such as Tobacco and cashew crops by Albuquerqque
- **Tobacco Cultivation:** Introduced **tobacco cultivation** to India, diversifying agricultural practices.
- **Printing Press:** Established the first **printing press** in Goa in **1556**, advancing literacy and communication.
- **Architecture:** Influenced **ecclesiastical architecture** in the Deccan region, exemplified by elaborate **Manuelesque buildings** along the western coast.
- **Set up military post and settlements** on east coast at San Thome(Chennai) and Nagapattinam(Tamilnadu)
- **Military Innovation** such as use of body armour, matchlock men and guns landed from ships

Dutch Rule in India

- **Beginning:** Driven by **commercial interests**, the Dutch ventured eastward, with Cornelis de Houtman's visit to Sumatra and Bantam marking their initial foray in **1596**.
- **Charter of Dutch Parliament (1602):** The **Dutch Parliament's Charter** in March **1602** formalized the establishment of the United East India Company of the Netherlands, granting it extensive powers including the authority to declare war, sign treaties, and establish forts.
- **Dutch Factories in India:** From **Masulipatnam** (1605) to **Cochin** (1663), the Dutch established numerous **factories** across both the eastern and western coasts of India, including Pulicat, Surat, and Nagapatnam.
- **Decline:**
  - **Focus on Indonesia:** With their primary commercial interests centered in the **Spice Islands of Indonesia**, the Dutch prioritized trade over imperial expansion in India.
  - **Anglo-Dutch War:** Following their defeat in the Anglo-Dutch conflicts, the Dutch redirected their attention towards the **Malay Archipelago**, shifting away from their presence in India.
  - **Battle of Bidara (1759):** After a prolonged conflict, the Dutch suffered defeat at the hands of the English in the **Battle of Bidara,** further contributing to their decline in India.

British Rule in India

The Company of Merchants of London Trading into the East Indies was the name of the Joint-Stock Company that later became the British East India Company. It was founded in 1600. In 1612, the Mughal emperor Jahangir gave Sir Thomas Roe, a representative diplomat of Queen Elizabeth I of England, permission to open a factory (a trade station) in Surat, giving the British Company its first foothold in India.

Formative Years of the East India Company	
1600	The East India Company was established.
1609	William Hawkins arrived at Jahangir's court.
1611	Captain Middleton obtained the permission of the Mughal governor of Surat to trade there.
1613	A permanent factory of East India Company was established at Surat.
1615	Sir Thomas Roe, the ambassador of King James I, arrived at Jahangir's court. By 1618, the ambassador succeeded in obtaining two farmans (one each from the emperor and Prince Khurram) confirming free trade with exemption from inland tolls.
1616	The Company established its first factory in the south in Masulipatnam.
1632	The Company got the golden farman from the Sultan of Golconda which ensured safety and prosperity of their trade.
1633	The Company established its first factory in east India in Hariharpur, Balasore (Odisha).
1639	The Company got the lease of Madras from a local king.
1651	The Company was given permission to trade at Hooghly (Bengal).
1662	The British King, Charles II, was given Bombay as dowry for marrying a Portuguese princess (Catherine of Braganza).

1667	Aurangzeb gave the English a farman for trade in Bengal.
1691	The Company got the imperial order to continue their trade in Bengal in lieu of payment of ₹ 3,000 a year.
1717	The Mughal emperor Farrukhsiyar issued a farman, called Magna Carta of the Company, giving the Company a large number of trade concessions.

French

French East India Company was founded in 1664 by Louis XIV's Minister Colbert, who also gave it a 50-year monopoly on French trade in the Indian and Pacific Oceans.

Settlements in India

1667: Francois Caron established Surat.

1669: Mercara, Masulipatnam permission from the Sultan of Golconda.

1673: Chandernagore, near Calcutta permission from Shaista Khan, the Mughal Subhadra of Bengal.

The Danes

The Danish East India Company, formed in 1616, established a factory at **Tranquebar** in **1620** and a main settlement at **Serampore**. Their Indian ventures were not significant, and in 1845, their factories were sold to the British. The Danes are more renowned for their missionary work than for commerce in India.

Comparison of Rule Under Various Imperialists

Aspect	Portuguese Rule in India	British Rule in India	French Rule in India	Dutch Rule in India
Time Period	1498-1961	1600-1947	1664-1954	1605-1824
Geographical Scope	Mainly concentrated in Goa	Widespread across Indian subcontinent	Presence in various regions, including Pondicherry and Chandernagore	Presence in Coromandel Coast, Malabar Coast, and Bengal
Focus of Rule	Trade, missionary activities, military control	Economic exploitation, administrative reforms, plantation economies	Economic exploitation, administrative reforms	Economic exploitation, trade dominance, establishment of trading posts
Cultural Influence	Imposed Portuguese language, culture, and religion	Introduced English language, legal systems, education	Introduced French language, legal systems, education	Introduced Dutch language, legal systems, education
Resistance Movements	Limited resistance due to authoritarian governance	Significant movements for independence and resistance	Movements for independence and resistance	Resistance from local rulers and European competitors
End of Rule	Ended in 1961 with Indian military action	Ended with Indian independence in 1947	Ended On November 1, 1954	Diminished due to British dominance, formally ended in 1825
Legacy	Legacy of Portuguese language, architecture, and Christianity	Legacy of English language, legal system, and institutions	Legacy of French language, architecture, and culture	Legacy of Dutch architecture, place names, and influence on local customs
Religious Inspiration	Inspired by Catholicism and orthodox Christianity	Rule influenced by Protestantism	Rule influenced by Catholicism and secular Enlightenment ideals	Inspired by Protestantism and commercial interests
Maritime vs. Mainland	Concentrated around coastal areas due to maritime strength	Focused on colonising mainland India based on diplomatic and military successes	Coastal presence with focus on trading posts	Coastal presence with emphasis on trade dominance

Why Britain Became the Dominant European Power in India

I. Advantages of the British East India Company:

- **Structure and Leadership:** Unlike state-controlled companies of other European powers, the English East India Company had a more dynamic structure. Elected directors influenced by shareholders ensured better decision-making and focus on profitability.
- **Naval Power:** Britain's Royal Navy, the largest and most advanced of its time, gave them a significant advantage in trade routes and military conflicts with other European powers in India.

II. Broader Societal and Technological Factors:

- **Industrial Revolution:** Britain's industrial revolution led to advancements in textile production, metallurgy, and steam power. This economic and technological edge allowed them to outpace other European nations.
- **Military Strength:** Well-trained and disciplined British soldiers, coupled with technological advancements, made their military a formidable force.
- **Stable Government:** Compared to the political instability faced by other European powers like France during the revolution and Napoleonic Wars, Britain enjoyed a period of relative stability, allowing for better strategic planning.
- **Financial Strength:** Britain's innovative use of debt markets through the Bank of England allowed them to outspend competitors on military campaigns.

III. Exploiting the Situation in India:

- **Power Vacuum:** The decline of the Mughal Empire and conflicts among regional rulers created an opportunity for the British to establish themselves in India.
- **Strong leadership:** Robert Clive, Warren Hastings, Elphinstone, Munro, and others demonstrated excellent leadership abilities. The British also benefited from second-line leaders like Sir Eyre Coote, Lord Lake, Arthur Wellesley, and others
- **Financial Resources:** Strong financial backing from the company and increased trade wealth allowed the British to sustain their military campaigns in India.

IV. Weaknesses of Indian Rulers:

- **Internal Divisions:** The British skillfully exploited the lack of national unity among Indian rulers, often inciting internal conflicts.
- **Military Inferiority:** Despite employing European weapons and personnel, Indian rulers lacked effective military strategies compared to the British.
- **Diplomacy:** The British cleverly used diplomatic tactics like the Doctrine of Lapse and Subsidiary Alliance to expand their control over Indian territories.

V. Cultural and Psychological Warfare:

- **Promotion of Western Education and Enlightenment Ideals:** To create a class of people who were "Indian in blood and color, but English in tastes, in opinions, in morals and in intellect," which facilitated easier governance and administration.
- **Use of Propaganda:** British propaganda depicted them as bearers of civilization and modernity, which helped legitimize their rule in the eyes of both Indians and Europeans, reducing the resistance to their expansion.

VI. Legal and Administrative Reforms:

- **Introduction of British Laws:** Introduction of British legal practices and administrative reforms such as the Permanent Settlement, which restructured land revenue systems to favour British economic interests, often at the expense of the local agrarian community.
- **Civil Service:** Establishment of a civil service that was loyal to the British Crown, which helped in the efficient and effective administration of a vast and diverse country like India.

In conclusion, a combination of factors – the efficient structure of the East India Company, advancements during the Industrial Revolution, a strong and stable government, and the ability to exploit internal divisions within India – allowed Britain to emerge as the dominant European power in India.

Socio- Economic and Political Condition of India in 18th Century

Social Conditions

- **Land of Contrast:** Extreme riches and magnificence coexisted with extreme poverty. The affluent and powerful nobility who lived in luxury and comfort on the one hand, and the backward, downtrodden, and impoverished peasants on the other.
- **Caste System:** Hierarchical division of society on the basis Varna vyavastha. Brahmin, kshtriya,Vaishya, shudra and one Avarna- Untouchables. Castes were strictly established, and each person's social standing was set for life.
- **Position of Women:** Women lacked individuality at the time. However, exceptions like Ahilya Bai successfully administered Indore from 1766 to 1796, and many other Hindu and Muslim women played important roles in 18th-century politics.

- **Education:**
  - **Higher education institutions:** They could be found all over the nation and were frequently supported by affluent zamindars, nawabs, and rajas.
  - **Elementary education:** It was widespread. Maulvis taught it to Muslims in maktabs in mosques and to Hindus in municipal and village schools.
  - **Literacy Level:** Unexpectedly, the literacy rate was not lower than it would subsequently be under the British. Despite being inadequate by today's standards, basic education was adequate for the time's specific needs.

Economic Conditions

- **Background:** The pre-colonial state's economic structure allowed it to be distinguished from the colonial state.
- **Trade and Industry:** flourished such as product exported from India-indigo, saltpetre, Opium, rice etc and products imported include gold, musk, dates, dried fruits, Coffee etc.
- **Burton Stein** put forth a number of possible causes for the 18th-century financial crises, including the standardisation of means of exchange in terms of money and metal content in coinage.
- **Increased Indebtedness:** According to **Ashin Das Gupta**, the company's corporate mercantile institutionalisation transcended political boundaries, and the abundance of credit caused the rate of debt to rise in both inland and export trade.
- **Dependence on Company:** In his depiction of commercial dependence on the company in North India, **BR Grover** claims that the vicissitudes led to a boom in foreign trade and the cotton industry.
- **Wealth accumulation by Zamindars:** The amassed wealth of the Zamindars and the high revenue settlements with the peasantry might be considered as the cause of the economic prosperity in the Mughal Empire's periphery.
- **Rise in demand for luxury goods:** East India's rise to prominence. The establishment of the company was the result of increased demand for upscale goods and labour coercion by local landlords and chieftains.

Political Conditions

- **Background:**
  - The Mughal Empire started to fall apart in the first decade of the seventeenth century.
  - By the start of our study period in 1739, Delhi had already been devastated by Nadir Shah's invasion in 1739.
  - In 1761, the Marathas, not the Mughals, engaged in battle with Abdali. The Mughal emperor was a British pensioner by 1783.
- **Constant Political Flux:** After the Battle of Buxar in 1764, the threatening British presence actually materialised. The British could advance further into North India because of the fall of Shaja-ud-Daulah, the Nawab of Awadh.
- **Assertion of Regional Identities:** Consistent resistance to the Mughal Empire was shown through the expression of regional identities, particularly in Deccan India. This resistance was bolstered by the assertion of the Sultanates in the territories of Golconda and Bijapur.
- **Rise of Northern Powers:** Due to rival northern powers like the Afghans, Sikhs, and aspiring Marathas, the Mughals lost their grasp on Delhi.
- **Lack of Strong Monarch:** According to **William Irvine,** this empire-centric strategy depended on a powerful emperor, and when the monarch's power waned, the system as a whole weakened India's political map.
- **Jagirdari Crisis:** The eventual collapse of the Mansabdari system, which was based on a person's loyalty, service, and Jagirdari status (land revenue holding), with a surge in Jagirdars towards the end of Aurangzeb's reign.

18th Century: A Dark Age

- **Disorder and instability**: The 18th century was once thought of as a Dark Age during which disorder and instability reigned.
- **Failure of Regional nations**: They failed to create empires after the fall of the Mughal Empire, and stability was only restored with the expansion of British control in the late 18th Century.
  - The influence of the Mughal Empire was not as extensive or profound as often thought.
  - Numerous social groups and substantial portions of India, particularly the North East and South, remained outside of it.
  - Therefore, the decline of the Mughals cannot be used as a sufficient theme to illustrate changes occurring throughout India.
- **Scholars' View**: According to historian Jadunath Sarkar, India's Middle Ages came to an end on June 23, 1757, and her Modern Age began. In the twenty years following Plassey Warren Hastings, everyone experienced the energising influence of the Western impetus.

Fragmented Polity in the 18th Century (UPSC 2017)

The difficulties this time period faced added to the threat of a divided democracy, creating a complicated and unstable political environment.

- **The Fall of the Mughal Empire:**
  - In the middle of the eighteenth century, the once-dominant Mughal Empire began to gradually crumble.
  - The empire was weakened by weak leaders, succession conflicts, and economic difficulties, which led to a loss of centralised authority. The fall of the Mughal Empire left a power vacuum, which allowed for the ascension of regional powers.
- **Rise of Regional Powers:**
  - Several regional powers, like the Marathas, Sikhs, Rajputs, and various province kingdoms, formed during this time.
  - Conflicts and polity disintegration resulted from these regional rulers' attempts to solidify their control and expand their spheres of influence.
  - Each authority followed its own objectives, further resulting in a fractured political system.
- **Resurgence of Local Economies and Crafts:**
  - Despite the overall economic difficulties caused by warfare and political instability, some regions experienced a resurgence in local crafts and trades. **For example,** regions like Awadh and Bengal saw a revival in textile production and trade, benefitting from decentralised control and local patronage, which allowed them to develop economic networks relatively independent of the imperial center.
- **European Colonial Influence:**
  - The fragmented polity was used by European colonial powers like the British, French, and Portuguese to increase their dominance.
  - They played off tensions amongst regional powers and used them to their advantage in order to gradually take over different territories.
  - By implementing the divide and rule strategy, the colonial powers further splintered the political system.

In conclusion, it is clear that the eighteenth century was a remarkable historical era that historians approached from two different angles. According to one school of historians, the tragic collapse of the Mughal Empire brought to "**chaos and anarchy.**" Another school of historians used a regionalist perspective, focusing on how the nearby communities grew into vibrant centres of socioeconomic activity.

Decline of the Mughal Empire in India

After Aurangzeb's death (1707), who left them with control of the largest empire, the later Mughals gradually came to the end of their era, which lasted for roughly 50 years. The following are the main reasons behind the Mughal Empire's decline.

- **Weak Successors And Foreign Invasion:** Aurangzeb's successors like Jahandar Shah, farukhsiyyar etc. were powerless to stop the collapse of the empire. The later Mughals did not adhere to any succession laws, and a new battle started every time an emperor passed away.
- **Financial Issues:** At this point, there was not enough money or jagirs to give to different authorities.
- **Weak Military Administration:** There were far too many high-ranking officials. Additionally, the army's effectiveness was not kept up.

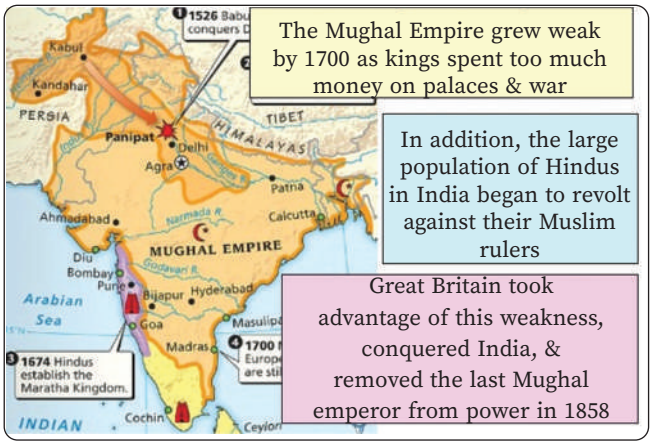

Fig. 1.2: Decline of the Mughal Empire

- **Economic Failure:** Luxurious living was another aspect of Mughal India, which consumed much of the income from the land and from trade leaving peasants and artisans with a difficult life.
- **Size of the Empire and Threat from Regional Powers:** As the Mughal Empire grew, Delhi was no longer able to serve as its capital.
- **Neglect of North-West border:** Later Mughal emperors neglected the northwestern boundary which made it possible for Nadir Shah Invasion(1739) and Ahmad Shah Abdali Invasion(Jan 1757) to repeatedly pillage Delhi.
- **Lack of Innovation:** No substantial innovation in science or technology made the issue worse.

Rise of Regional States

The decline of the Mughal Empire in the 18th century created a power vacuum in India, leading to the rise of several regional states. These states exhibited a range of characteristics that contributed to their emergence and shaped their trajectories. Here's a critical assessment of some key features:

Military Strength

- **Adoption of Gunpowder Technology:** Most states incorporated Mughal-style gunpowder weaponry and fortresses into their military strategies.
- **Emphasis on Cavalry:** Most regional states relied heavily on cavalry, a legacy of the Mughals. However, some, like the Marathas, with their guerilla tactics and adaptability, proved to be more successful against larger, less mobile forces.
- **Firearms and European Influence:** The adoption of firearms from European powers like the Portuguese and Ottomans played a significant role in warfare. States like the Sikhs and Mysore actively incorporated these technologies.

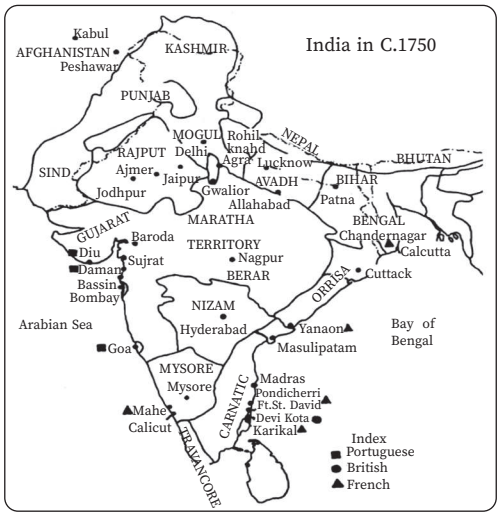

Fig. 1.3: India in 18th Century

Leadership and Administration

- **Charismatic Leaders:** Several states rose to prominence under the guidance of charismatic leaders like Shivaji of the Marathas, Hyder Ali and Tipu Sultan of Mysore, and Raja Todar Mal of Mewar. These leaders' vision, military prowess, and administrative acumen were crucial to state formation.
- **Varied Administrative Systems:** The structures differed. The Marathas had a relatively decentralized system with semi-autonomous chiefs, while Mysore under Haider Ali and Tipu Sultan had a strong centralized administration. The effectiveness of these systems depended on leadership and regional context.

Economic Policies

- **Focus on Revenue Generation:** Most states focused on maximizing revenue collection through land taxes and control of trade routes. Mysore, for instance, promoted commercial crop cultivation.
- **Trade and Commerce:** Some states, like the Marathas and Gujarat Sultanate, actively participated in regional and international trade, leveraging their geographical location. This trade provided them with wealth and resources for expansion.

Social and Religious Landscape

- **Religious Tolerance:** While some states like Mysore under Haider Ali were known for religious tolerance, others like the Sikh kingdom under Ranjit Singh had a more specific religious identity.
- **Social Reforms:** Some rulers, like Tipu Sultan of Mysore, attempted social reforms to address issues like sati (widow burning) and female infanticide. However, the effectiveness and reach of such reforms varied.
- **Religious Identity:** In other cases, religion played a more unifying role. The Sikh kingdom, **For example,** was founded on a distinct religious identity that motivated its people.

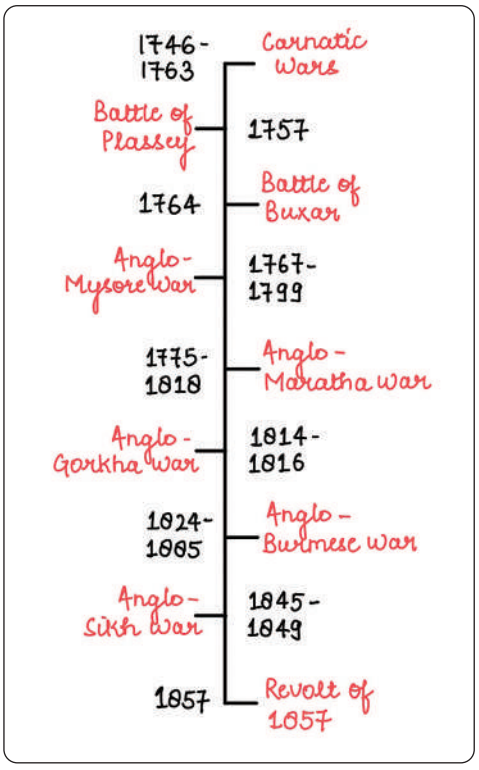

Fig. 1.4: Major Wars with Britishers
Diagram Type: *Timeline*

Political Systems

- **Monarchical Forms:** Most states were monarchies, with hereditary rule by kings or Nawabs. However, legitimacy often relied on military strength and administrative efficiency rather than solely on lineage.
- **Decentralization:** While some states like Mysore under Haider Ali had strong central administration, others like the Marathas exhibited a more decentralized structure with semi-autonomous chiefs.
- **Varying Degrees of Stability:** The stability of these states differed. Kingdoms like Travancore under the Dharma Raja administration enjoyed relative stability, while the Maratha Confederacy faced internal conflicts between different factions.

Limitations and Vulnerabilities

- **Limited Technological Advancement:** While some states adopted firearms, they generally lagged behind European powers in military technology and modernization. This technological gap proved critical in the later conflicts with the British.
- **Power Struggles and Fragmentation:** The competition for dominance among these regional states often led to ongoing conflicts, contributing to a fragmented political landscape in India.
- **Laying the Groundwork for the Future:** Despite the challenges, these regional states experimented with diverse political and economic systems, paving the way for future developments in Indian governance.

- **Resistance to Colonialism:** Some states, like Mysore, actively resisted British East India Company expansion, showcasing a spirit of anti-colonialism.

The emergence of regional states after the Mughals presented a complex and multifaceted picture of Indian politics. While military strength, leadership, and economic policies were crucial for their emergence, internal rivalries and limited technological advancements ultimately contributed to their vulnerability in the face of a rising British Empire. Understanding these characteristics allows for a nuanced analysis of this dynamic period in Indian history.

Rise of Marathas: Factors Responsible for the Rise of Marathas

- **Language and literature have an impact:** Eknath encouraged pride in the Marathas' native tongue, which helped foster a sense of community and belonging among the Marathas.
- **The geographical circumstances:** The Maratha Empire's rise to power was facilitated by Maharashtra's location and other natural characteristics.
- **Training in managing affairs:** Long before Shivaji came to power, the Marathas had acquired knowledge and training in managing affairs.
- **The unstable political condition of the South:** The Muslim kingdoms in the South were in danger of disintegrating due to the unsteady political situation there. The political environment was favourable for the Marathas to seize control.
- **The charismatic nature of Shivaji:** Prior to Shivaji Maharaj's ascendance, the Maratha race was dispersed over a number of Deccan kingdoms like atoms.
- **Guerrilla warfare:** The Marathas were able to deploy guerilla warfare to a great extent because of the difficult terrain.

Anglo-Maratha Wars

Battle	Year	Parties Involved	Result/Aftermath
First Anglo-Maratha War	1775-1782	British East India Company vs Marathas (under Peshwa Madhavrao II)	Treaty of Salbai (1782)-British recognised Madhavrao II as Peshwa; status quo maintained
Second Anglo-Maratha War	1803-1805	British vs Scindia, Bhonsle, Holkar (Maratha chiefs)	Treaties of Bassein (1802), Deogaon (Dec, 1803), and Surji-Anjangaon (Dec, 1803); Treaty of Rajpurghat (1806) Marathas lost territory, British influence increased
Third Anglo-Maratha War	1817-1818	British vs Peshwa Baji Rao II and other Maratha forces	Treaty of poona, (June 1817), Treaty of Gwalior, (November 1817), Treaty of mandsour, (Jan 1818). End of Maratha Confederacy Territories annexed, Baji Rao II pensioned off, British supremacy

Fall of Marathas: Why the Marathas Couldn't Replace the Mughals

- **War of Succession:** After Shivaji's death, his sons- Shambaji and Rajaram engaged in a fight for succession.
- **Political organisation (within):** It had the characteristics of a confederacy where the heads or sardars (Bhonsle, Holker, etc.) shared power.
- **Weak tax administration:** The Chauth and Sardeshmukhi collections, as well as their exploits in stealing and looting, were crucial to the Marathas. They were unable to create a productive revenue administration system.
- **Weak Diplomacy:** The Marathas failed to forge alliances with forces around them because they did not take the time to learn what was going elsewhere and what their rivals were doing.
- **Subsidiary Alliance and the Anglo-Maratha Wars:** By signing the Treaty of Bassein in 1802, Peshwa Baji Rao II agreed to a subsidiary alliance. This marked the downfall of the Maratha empire.

The Maratha Empire, afterwards known as the Maratha Confederacy, ruled a sizable portion of early modern India in the 18th century. The rise of the Marathas in the seventeenth century is a major and fascinating development in Indian history. Shivaji and the conditions that shaped his and his allies' personalities are primarily to blame for this rise.

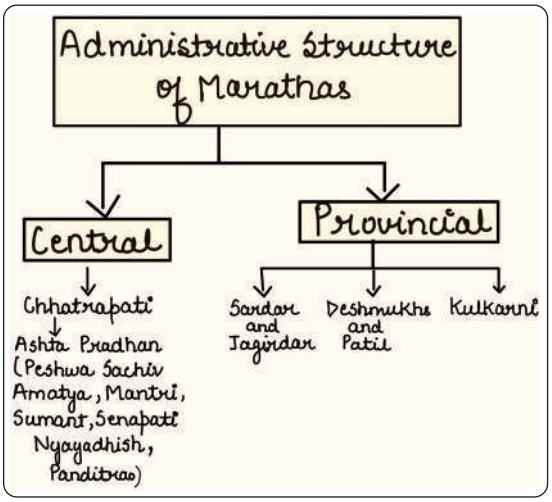

Fig. 1.5: Administrative Structure of Marathas
Diagram Type: *Hierarchy*

Panipat (Haryana) as Favourite Battlefield (UPSC 2014)

- **Strategic Significance of Location:**
  - Its location along the Yamuna River's banks made it the perfect spot for the transportation of troops and supplies.
  - The Grand Trunk Road, which served as the primary commerce route between North India and Central Asia, is also where it is situated.
  - Served as a natural gateway for armies from the north and northwest, including the formidable Khyber Pass route, aiming to capture the political hub of northern India, Delhi.
- **Political Relevance:**
  - North India was split up into several minor kingdoms that were continually striving for dominance during the mediaeval era.
  - At the intersection of numerous significant kingdoms, including Delhi, Agra, and Jaipur, stood Panipat.
- **Unbiased ground**: Its remote location made it less susceptible to political pressure because it was removed from the other kingdoms' political hotspots.
- **Proximity to Delhi:** Panipat's proximity to Delhi facilitated the swift deployment of troops, weaponry, and supplies to the battleground while safeguarding the capital from immediate threats.
- **Terrain Advantages:** The flat terrain in the Panipat region was well-suited for mounted cavalry, which was the predominant mode of warfare during those times.
- **Climate Considerations:** The region's relatively shorter monsoon season, compared to other areas, made it an ideal setting for military confrontations.
- **Local Craftsmanship and War Equipment Supply:** Local craftsmen excelled in the production of war equipment, ensuring a convenient supply of weaponry for both opposing armies. This factor played a crucial role in the battles fought at Panipat.

Notable Battles at Panipat

- **The First Battle of Panipat (1526):** The first Battle of Panipat in 1526 was a pivotal clash between Babur and Ibrahim Lodi. This battle laid the foundation for the Mughal Empire, bringing an end to the rule of the Delhi Sultanate.
- **The Second Battle of Panipat (1556):** In 1556, the Second Battle of Panipat took place, with Akbar facing off against Hemu. This battle decided in favor of the continuation of Mughal rule in India.
- **The Third Battle of Panipat (1761):** The Third Battle of Panipat in 1761 witnessed the Marathas pitted against Ahmad Shah Abdali. This battle marked the termination of the Maratha's ambitions to rule over India.

The location of Delhi itself was ideal: Delhi was well situated between two affluent agricultural regions, namely the plains of the Indus and the plains of the Ganges.

Wars and Treaties

War	Year and Place	People Involved	Battles/ Seiges/Treaties	Important Details	Result
First Anglo Mysore war	1767-69 Mysore Border	Hyder Ali[Nizam of Hyderabad], Joseph Smith, Colonel Brooks, Madhav Rao	- Battle of Chengam, Tiruvannamalai - Seige of Ambur - Battle of Ooscota, Mulwagul and Baugloor	- Hyder Ali Friendship with French - Mysore Border Dispute Between the Madras Govt. and Nawab of Carnatic	Hyder Ali Edge Over English
Second Anglo Mysore war	1780-84 Carnatic [Arcot]	Hyder Ali, Tipu Sultan, Eyre Coote and Hector Munro	- Battle of Porto Novo - Treaties of Mangalore - Seige of Mysore - Battle of Pollilur and Sholinghur	- Capture of Mahe by English - Marathas+Nizams Sided with English - Hyder Ali Defeated	Drawn Struggle
Third Anglo Mysore war	1790-92 Malabar Coast	Tipu Sultan, Cornwallis and William Medows	- Battle of Tellicherry - Treaty of Seringapatam	- Tipu's attack on Travancore - Lost his son and half of his territory - 2 Sons kept as prisoners	English Victory
Fourth Anglo Mysore war	1799 Sriranga Patnam	Tipu Sultan, Wellesley, Asaf Jha II, James stuart	- Battle of Seringapatam and Mallavelly - Siege of Seringapatnam	- Napolean plan to invade India and Tipu's Negotiations - Tipu was killed - Mysore lost Independence	English Victory

Fig. 1.6: Anglo Mysore Wars

Expansion and Consolidation of British Power in India

The British expanded and consolidated their power by annexing states right from the Battle of Plassey in 1757 to the annexation of Punjab in 1849.

Annexation of States with Wars

States Annexed	Policy of Annexation
Bengal	❖ **Battle of Plassey, 1757:** Robert Clive's victory over Siraj-ud-daula laid the territorial foundation of British rule in India ❖ **Battle of Buxar, 1764:** Clive's victory over the combined armies of Nawab of Bengal, Nawab of Awadh ❖ and the Mughal ruler laid the real foundation of the English power ❖ **Treaty of Allahabad, 1765**: Granted the Diwani Rights of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa to the English ❖ **Dual government** from 1765 to 1772
Mysore	❖ **1st Anglo-Mysore War (1767-69):** Treaty of Madras ❖ **2nd Anglo-Mysore War (1780-84):** Treaty of Mangalore ❖ **3rd Anglo-Mysore War (1790-92):** Treaty of Seringapatam ❖ **4th Anglo-Mysore War (1799):** Mysore conquered by the British forces
Maratha	❖ **1st Anglo-Maratha War (1775-82):** Treaty of Surat, Treaty of Purandhar, Treaty of Salbai ❖ **2nd Anglo-Maratha War (1803-05):** Treaty of Bassein ❖ **3rd Anglo-Maratha War (1817-19):** Complete annexation of the Maratha kingdom by the British
Sindh	❖ In 1843, under Governor-General Ellenborough, Sindh was merged into the British empire by the efforts of Charles Napier
Punjab	❖ **Treaty of Amritsar** ❖ **1st Anglo-Sikh war (1845-46)** ❖ **2nd Anglo-Sikh war (1848-49)**

Annexation of States Without War

Administrative Policy	States Annexed
❖ **Policy of Ring Fence (1765-1813):** ➢ To fortify the Company's frontiers by establishing buffer zones. ➢ In general, it was a strategy of defending their neighbours' borders to protect their territories.	❖ Awadh was used as a buffer state post the Battle of Buxar
❖ **Subsidiary Alliance (1798 onwards)** ➢ The company's soldiers had to be installed under this method by the Indian kings. ➢ They also had to cover all the costs associated with running the troops and the rulers must continue to host British citizens in their courts. ➢ They were forbidden from negotiating with any other Indian rulers without British consent. ➢ The alliance was a strategy to counter the Napoleon menace, which posed a real danger to the company.	❖ Hyderabad ❖ Mysore ❖ Tanjore etc
❖ **Doctrine of Lapse (1848-1859)** ➢ According to the doctrine, if a princely state subject to the company's vassalage fails to produce an heir, the land will be annexed by the British.	❖ Satara ❖ Jhansi ❖ Nagpur ❖ Udaipur etc
❖ **Doctrine of Mis-governance (1848-1856)** ➢ Annexation of the Indian states based on maladministration by the Indian ruler.	❖ Awadh
❖ **Policy of Masterly Inactivity (1864)** ➢ The English shouldn't interfere in Afghanistan's domestic affairs and there was no need to maintain an English representative at its court.	❖ Afghanistan

❖ **Policy of Proud Reserve (1874)** ➢ Lytton started a new foreign policy of 'Proud Reserve', which was aimed at having scientific frontiers and safeguarding 'spheres of influence'. ➢ Relations with Afghanistan could no longer be kept ambiguous.	❖ Afghanistan

Contradiction: Armies of the British East India Company With Indian Soldiers Win Against Armies of the Indian Rulers (UPSC 2022)

The British East India Company, which relied heavily on Indian soldiers, was able to continually defeat the armies of Indian rulers for a number of reasons:

1. **Diplomatic Mastery and Strategic Alliances**: The **British East India Company** adeptly exploited divisions among **Indian rulers** through strategic alliances, fracturing opposition forces and consolidating their own power base.
2. **Technological Supremacy**: Armed with modern weaponry like muskets and cannons, the **British** enjoyed a decisive **technological advantage** over indigenous forces, bolstering their battlefield prowess.
3. **Organisational Efficiency**: The British Army's superior **organisation** and **training** stood in stark contrast to the often disorganised and untrained **Indian forces**, enhancing their combat effectiveness.
4. **Financial Superiority**: The substantial **financial resources** of the **British East India Company** facilitated the recruitment and equipping of sizable armies, while also enabling the manipulation of local authorities through bribery, further solidifying their dominance.
5. **Naval Dominance and Logistical Edge**: Control over the seas granted the British East India Company unparalleled **logistical flexibility**, allowing for swift troop movements and supply lines, a capability beyond the reach of indigenous rulers.
6. **Unified Command Structure and Professionalism**: Under a centralised and well-organised command structure, the **British forces** exhibited greater **coordination** and **efficiency** in military operations compared to the fragmented commands of their adversaries.
7. **External Support and Exceptional Leadership**: Backed by the crown, Parliament, and guided by exemplary leadership, the British forces enjoyed crucial **external support** and **leadership**, which further fortified their military endeavours and ensured sustained success on the battlefield.

Through a combination of diplomatic finesse, technological supremacy, organisational efficiency, financial leverage, naval dominance, unified command, external support, and exceptional leadership, the British East India Company established military hegemony over the Indian subcontinent, laying the foundation for enduring colonial rule.

Administration before 1857

Administration in India till 1858 was in the hands of the East India Company, a monopoly trading body. To regulate its management of Indian affairs, the British Parliament passed two major Acts, the Regulating Act and Pitt's India Act. Subsequently, Acts of 1793, 1813, 1833 and 1853 were passed by which the Company was steadily deprived of its authority and power in India and its privileges curtailed.

Features of the Administration of East India Company

- **Commercial in Nature:** Basically government by Council, which had executive and legislative powers with the Governor or the Governor-General having the casting vote.
- **A Government by Boards:** viz, Board of Trade, Revenue Board, Military Board etc
- **A Government by Record:** When transactions were commercial, records were brief and manageable. But political dealings made record-keeping cumbersome and voluminous.
- **Mismanaged the administration of acquired territories:** One example is Clive's Double or Dual Government of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa which resulted in rampant corruption and bankruptcy.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	Why did the armies of the British East India Company – mostly comprising of Indian soldiers – win consistently against the more numerous and better-equipped armies of the Indian rulers? Give reasons	2022
2.	Clarify how mid-eighteenth-century India was beset with the spectre of a fragmented polity.	2017
3.	The third battle of Panipat was fought in 1761. Why were so many empire-shaking battles fought at Panipat?	2014

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